

Lesson 08

Cross-Cultural Skills



Warm-Up

1. *Have you ever worked with people from a different culture?*
2. *What differences did you notice?*
3. *How do people in your country greet each other in business?*



Role-play

Scenario: *You are working on an international team with a new colleague from another country. You need to discuss how to communicate effectively while respecting each other's cultural differences.*

Student A: *You are from a culture that values direct communication and clear instructions. You prefer short emails and direct feedback.*

Student B: *You are from a culture that values indirect communication and polite language. You prefer building relationships before discussing work.*

Greeting and Small Talk

A: Hi (Colleague's Name), nice to meet you. How is your day going?

B: Nice to meet you too! In my culture, we usually start meetings with a little small talk. How do you like to begin?

Discussing Communication Styles

A: In my culture, we prefer direct communication. If something needs to be changed, we say it clearly.

B: I understand that in your culture, it's common to be direct. In my culture, we usually give feedback in a softer way.

Handling Misunderstandings

A: Oh, I didn't mean to offend you. In my culture, this is normal.

B: No problem! Could you clarify that, please?

Finding a Solution

A: Let's find a way that works for both of us. Maybe we can combine direct feedback with polite expressions?

B: That sounds good! Could you explain how this is done in your workplace?

Role-play Analysis

Answer the following questions:

1. What was the main cultural difference between the two colleagues?
2. How did Student A and Student B adapt to each other's communication style?
3. Which key phrases helped resolve misunderstandings?
4. What was the final solution they agreed on?
5. How would you handle a similar situation in your workplace?

Discussion

How can understanding cultural differences in communication help improve teamwork and professional relationships in a global workplace?



Practice

A. Fill-in the blanks Activity

Instructions: Students complete the sentences using the correct word or phrase from the box.

confidence body language clarify relationships indirect

1. In some cultures, a firm handshake is a sign of _____.
2. People from high-context cultures rely more on _____ than words.
3. If you don't understand something, you can ask: "Could you _____ that?"
4. In business, small talk is important because it helps build _____.
5. Some cultures prefer _____ communication, meaning they avoid saying "no" directly.

B. Multiple Choice

Instructions:

- ❖ Read the question and **discuss your answer** before choosing the best option.
- ❖ After selecting an answer, **explain why** you chose it using key phrases like:
 - *I think the best answer is... because in some cultures...*
 - *In my opinion, this is correct because...*
 - *Could you clarify why you chose that answer?*

1. **In some cultures, people avoid direct eye contact because:**
 - a) They are not interested in the conversation.
 - b) It is a sign of politeness and respect.
 - c) They are always shy.
2. **If your international colleague communicates very directly, what should you do?**
 - a) Assume they are being rude.
 - b) Ignore their message.
 - c) Understand that different cultures have different communication styles.
3. **Your colleague says, “*Let’s find a way that works for both of us.*”. What are they doing?**
 - a) Making a complaint.
 - b) Suggesting a compromise.
 - c) Ending the conversation.
4. **In low-context cultures (e.g., the U.S.), business emails are usually:**
 - a) Very formal and indirect.
 - b) Clear, short, and direct.
 - c) Full of small talk.
5. **Your colleague from another country does not respond to your email immediately. What should you do?**
 - a) Assume they are ignoring you.
 - b) Follow up politely and ask for an update.
 - c) Send the same email again every hour.



Stressed Syllables

Practice pronouncing these words with the correct stress:

1. **CUL**ture
2. **ET**tiquette
3. di**VER**sity
4. pro**FES**sionalism
5. **COUR**tesy



Production

Scenario: Two colleagues from different cultural backgrounds are working together on a project. One prefers direct communication, while the other prefers indirect communication. A misunderstanding occurs.

Student A: Comes from a culture where direct feedback is normal. They say:

“This report is unclear. You need to make it better.”

Student B: Comes from a culture where indirect feedback is preferred. They feel uncomfortable but want to respond professionally.

A: This report is unclear. You need to make it better.

B: Oh... I see. Could you clarify what needs improvement, please?

A: The data analysis section is too short. Could you add more details?

B: I understand that in your culture, it's common to be direct. In my culture, we usually give feedback in a softer way.

A: I didn't mean to offend you. In my culture, this is normal.

B: No problem! Let's find a way that works for both of us.

Discussion

1. What was the most difficult part of the conversation?
2. How did you solve the cultural misunderstanding?
3. How can you apply this in a real workplace?



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
Culture	The beliefs, customs, and social behavior of a particular group or society.	<i>In Japanese culture, bowing is a common way to show respect.</i>
Direct Communication	A communication style where people express themselves clearly and openly.	<i>In Germany, direct communication is valued in business meetings.</i>
Indirect Communication	A communication style where messages are suggested rather than stated explicitly.	<i>In Japan, people may say 'That will be difficult' instead of directly refusing a request.</i>
Hierarchy	Used in the ranking of individuals within an organization or society.	<i>In many Asian companies, employees show deference to senior managers due to hierarchy.</i>
Etiquette	The rules of polite behavior in a society or group.	<i>Good table etiquette is important during a business dinner in France.</i>



Wrap-Up

"To effectively communicate, we must realize that we are all different in the way we perceive the world."

Why is it important to adapt our communication style when working with international colleagues?